

The Arbiter's Awakening

Chapter 4: First Blood

Day 26 Since Awakening

Hayami stood at the entrance to Gate #SB-559, checking their equipment for the third time. Combat boots—check. Basic leather armor they'd purchased yesterday for ¥45,000—check. A borrowed short sword from the Association's equipment loaner program—check. Three mana potions in their inventory—check.

Their hands weren't shaking this time. That was progress.

[STATS]

- Strength: 33
- Agility: 40 (+5 from boots)
- Vitality: 35 (+3 from boots)
- Intelligence: 37
- Sense: 34

[LEVEL: 8] [EXP: 2,847/5,000]

The team leader for this raid was a D-rank Hunter named Sato, a heavysset man in his forties with the casual confidence of someone who'd cleared hundreds of Gates. He looked Hayami up and down with barely concealed skepticism.

"You're the E-rank combat support?"

"Yes."

"Says here you've done one mining job." Sato scrolled through his tablet. "No combat experience. Why'd you apply for a combat position?"

"Need the practice." Hayami met his gaze evenly. "And the pay."

Sato snorted. "Honest, at least. Fine. Here's how this works: you stay behind the main combat team and handle any stragglers that get past us. Think of yourself as a safety net. If something comes at you, you deal with it. If you can't deal with it, you scream for help. Do not—and I mean do not—try to engage the main monster groups. That's how E-ranks die."

"Understood."

"Your weapon?" Sato eyed the borrowed sword.

Hayami drew it slightly. The blade was standard issue, nothing special, but serviceable. "Association loaner."

"Get a real weapon after this job. That thing's garbage." Sato turned to address the full team. "Alright, listen up! This is a D-rank Gate, standard cave system, primary monsters are Shadow Bats and Stone Scorpions. Bats come in swarms but die easy. Scorpions have armor and poison—aim for the joints. We clear room by room, methodical and safe. Questions?"

No one had questions. This was routine for everyone except Hayami.

They entered the Gate.

[NOTICE: You have entered a D-Rank Gate] [Gate Name: Darkstone Caverns] [Estimated Difficulty: D] [Recommended Level: 25-35]

The cavern was different from the Crimson Hollows—darker, colder, with the constant sound of dripping water echoing from unseen depths. Bioluminescent moss provided minimal light, casting everything in sickly green shadows.

The combat team moved in formation: Sato in front with a massive shield, two D-rank damage dealers on the flanks, one C-rank mage in the back for ranged support. Hayami followed at a distance, eyes scanning for threats.

They didn't have to wait long.

The Shadow Bats came in a chittering swarm—dozens of them, each about the size of a cat, with wings that seemed to absorb light. The combat team handled them efficiently, the mage launching fireballs that incinerated clusters while the melee fighters cut down stragglers.

One bat broke through the formation, diving straight for Hayami.

[SHADOW BAT - LEVEL 18] [HP: 450/450]

Hayami's body moved before their mind caught up. Lightning Step activated, and suddenly they were three meters to the left, the bat's claws scraping air where they'd been standing. They pivoted, raised their right hand, and channeled Lightning Strike.

Blue-white electricity exploded from their palm, crossing the distance in a flash. The bolt caught the bat mid-flight, and the creature shrieked, its body convulsing. The smell of burning flesh filled the air.

[CRITICAL HIT!] [SHADOW BAT DEFEATED] [+450 EXP]

The notification flashed across Hayami's vision, and time seemed to slow. Experience points. From killing monsters. The realization hit them like a physical force.

They'd been so focused on the daily quests, so absorbed in training, that they'd completely overlooked the most obvious source of experience. Combat. Actual hunting.

More bats broke through the formation—three of them this time, drawn by the scent of blood. Hayami didn't hesitate. Lightning Step to close distance, Lightning Strike on the first bat, draw the sword for the second, Lightning Strike again for the third.

[SHADOW BAT DEFEATED] [+450 EXP]

[SHADOW BAT DEFEATED] [+450 EXP]

[SHADOW BAT DEFEATED] [+450 EXP]

[LEVEL UP!] [LEVEL 8 → LEVEL 9] [+5 STAT POINTS AVAILABLE FOR DISTRIBUTION]

Hayami's breath caught. Level up. And unlike the automatic stat distribution from daily quests, these points were theirs to assign. They pulled up the stat allocation screen:

[DISTRIBUTE 5 STAT POINTS]

- Strength: 33 [+]
- Agility: 40 [+]
- Vitality: 35 [+]
- Intelligence: 37 [+]
- Sense: 34 [+]

This changed everything. The daily quests gave broad, even growth. But level-ups let them specialize. Build toward a specific combat style. Optimize their strengths and shore up weaknesses.

They distributed the points quickly: +2 to Intelligence (for more mana and stronger lightning), +2 to Agility (for better combat mobility), +1 to Sense (for threat detection).

[STATS UPDATED]

- Strength: 33
- Agility: 42 (+5 from boots)
- Vitality: 35 (+3 from boots)
- Intelligence: 39

- Sense: 35

[MANA: 390/390]

The power flowed through them immediately, settling into their body like it had always been there. Their mind felt sharper. Their movements more precise.

"Hey, E-rank!" Sato called from ahead. "You good back there?"

"Fine!" Hayami jogged to catch up, their new stats making the movement feel effortless. "Just handled some stragglers."

Sato glanced back at the bat corpses, already dissolving into dark mist. "Not bad. Keep it up."

The raid continued deeper into the caverns. The combat team cleared chamber after chamber with mechanical efficiency, and Hayami stayed vigilant in the back, picking off any monsters that slipped through.

Each kill brought experience. Small amounts for the Level 18 bats, but it added up. By the time they reached the third chamber, Hayami had killed seven more bats and two Stone Scorpions that had tried to flank the formation.

[STONE SCORPION - LEVEL 22] [HP: 1,200/1,200]

The scorpions were harder. Their stone-like carapaces absorbed most damage, forcing Hayami to aim for the joints like Sato had instructed. Lightning Strike worked, but it took three hits to bring one down. The sword was almost useless—the blade couldn't penetrate the armor.

But Hayami was learning. Adapting. Each fight taught them something new about timing, positioning, resource management. They started conserving mana, using the sword for weaker enemies and saving Lightning Strike for threats that required it.

[STONE SCORPION DEFEATED] [+880 EXP]

[STONE SCORPION DEFEATED] [+880 EXP]

[LEVEL UP!] [LEVEL 9 → LEVEL 10] [+5 STAT POINTS AVAILABLE]

Two level-ups in one raid. Hayami allocated the points immediately: +2 Intelligence, +2 Agility, +1 Vitality. Their mana pool jumped to 410, and they felt the corresponding increase in their lightning's power.

The pattern was clear now. Higher-level monsters gave more experience. A Level 22 scorpion gave nearly twice what a Level 18 bat did. And if Hayami could find even higher-level targets...

They filed that thought away for later.

Four hours into the raid, the combat team reached what Sato called "the nest"—a massive chamber filled with at least fifty Shadow Bats roosting on the ceiling. The moment the team entered, the entire swarm descended.

"Formation!" Sato bellowed, his shield coming up to block a wave of claws. "Mage, area denial! Melee, tight grouping! E-rank, watch our backs!"

The chamber erupted into chaos. Fire and lightning—not Hayami's, the C-rank mage's—filled the air. Bats shrieked and died in droves. But the sheer numbers were overwhelming, and dozens broke through the defensive line.

Hayami found themselves facing eight bats at once.

Their mind went cold and clear. Lightning Step forward into the swarm, Lightning Strike at point-blank range taking out three bats in one shot. Sword slash for the fourth—messy, inefficient, but it worked. Lightning Step again to avoid claws, another Lightning Strike catching two more mid-flight.

[MANA: 210/410]

Half their mana gone. Two bats left. Hayami couldn't waste more energy. They dropped into a combat stance they'd practiced on the apartment roof and waited for the bats to commit.

The first bat dove. Hayami sidestepped and brought the sword up in a clean arc. The blade caught the bat's wing, sending it spiraling. The second bat was right behind it. No time for technique. Hayami channeled lightning through their free hand—not a full Strike, just raw electricity—and grabbed the bat out of the air.

The creature convulsed in their grip, dying instantly.

[SHADOW BAT DEFEATED] x8 [+3,600 EXP]

Hayami dropped the corpse and scanned for more threats. The combat team had handled the main swarm. Bodies were dissolving into mist all around them. It was over.

"Clear!" Sato announced. "Good work, everyone. E-rank, you're still alive. That's better than most first combat raids."

Hayami was breathing hard, adrenaline making their hands shake. But underneath the fear and exhaustion was something else. Excitement. They'd just fought off eight monsters simultaneously and won. A month ago, they couldn't do twenty push-ups. Now they were killing D-rank monsters.

The System had been right to push them. Every daily quest, every doubled training session, every stat point—it all mattered. It all led to this moment.

They checked their experience:

[EXP: 8,127/12,000]

Halfway to Level 11. And the raid wasn't even over yet.

The boss room was at the deepest point of the caverns—a chamber three times the size of any they'd encountered, with a ceiling that disappeared into darkness. In the center, curled around a pillar of stone, was something that made Hayami's blood run cold.

[STONE BROODMOTHER - LEVEL 35] [BOSS MONSTER] [HP: 15,000/15,000]

It was massive—easily five meters long, a scorpion the size of a small car with a carapace that looked like polished granite. Its tail curved overhead, the stinger dripping with luminescent purple venom.

"Alright," Sato said, his voice tight. "This is where you earn your pay. E-rank, you stay at the entrance. Do not engage the boss. Your job is to handle any adds that spawn. Boss fights always spawn adds. You keep them off our backs, we kill the boss. Everyone clear?"

The combat team moved into position. Hayami stayed at the entrance, sword drawn, eyes scanning the shadows.

The fight began with a roar. The Broodmother moved with terrifying speed for something its size, its tail lashing out in wide arcs that forced the melee fighters to dodge constantly. The C-rank mage launched spell after spell, but the carapace absorbed most of the damage.

Then the adds spawned.

Small scorpions—maybe half a meter long—erupted from cracks in the walls. Dozens of them, all Level 18, all heading straight for the combat team's exposed backs.

Hayami stepped forward to intercept.

[STONE SCORPLING - LEVEL 18] x12 [HP: 600/600 each]

A dozen scorplings. Too many for careful, efficient combat. This needed area damage.

Hayami planted their feet, raised both hands, and channeled everything they'd learned from the Training Manual. The electricity gathered in their core, built up through their meridians, concentrated in their palms. Not a focused strike—a spread. A chain reaction.

"Chain Lightning," Hayami whispered, attempting a technique from the Intermediate Manual they'd only practiced once.

The lightning exploded outward in branching arcs, leaping from one scorpling to the next in a crackling web of blue-white energy. The creatures shrieked and convulsed, their smaller bodies unable to withstand the sustained

electrical current.

[CHAIN LIGHTNING - IMPROVISED TECHNIQUE] [MANA COST: 150]

[STONE SCORPLING DEFEATED] x12 [+7,200 EXP]

[LEVEL UP!] [LEVEL 10 → LEVEL 11] [+5 STAT POINTS AVAILABLE]

[LEVEL UP!] [LEVEL 11 → LEVEL 12] [+5 STAT POINTS AVAILABLE]

Two level-ups. From one technique. Hayami stared at the notifications, barely processing them. They'd just jumped two levels in seconds.

More scorplings spawned. Hayami didn't hesitate. Lightning Strike. Sword slash. Another improvised Chain Lightning when a group clustered together. They fell into a rhythm, their increased stats making every movement faster, smoother, more effective.

Behind them, the combat team was making progress. The Broodmother's HP was dropping steadily: 12,000... 9,000... 6,000...

More adds spawned. Hayami handled them. Their mana was running low—down to 80 from the repeated Chain Lightnings—but they managed. Sword work. Precise lightning usage. Conservation.

[STONE BROODMOTHER DEFEATED]

The boss's death cry shook the chamber. Its massive body dissolved into mist, leaving behind a pile of loot that made Sato whistle appreciatively.

"Nice work, team." He turned to look at Hayami, his expression shifting from skepticism to something almost like respect. "E-rank. You handled those adds like a professional. Good job."

Hayami nodded, too tired to speak. They allocated their ten stat points quickly: +4 Intelligence, +3 Agility, +2 Vitality, +1 Sense.

[LEVEL: 12] [STATS]

- Strength: 33
- Agility: 47 (+5 from boots)
- Vitality: 37 (+3 from boots)
- Intelligence: 43
- Sense: 36

[MANA: 430/430]

From Level 8 to Level 12 in one raid. Four levels. Twenty stat points. This was exponentially faster than daily quests alone.

The loot distribution took twenty minutes. The combat team got the majority—boss drops, rare materials, high-value stones. Hayami received their contracted payment of ¥75,000 plus a small share of the monster stone haul, adding another ¥40,000.

Sato approached as they were preparing to leave. "You did good work today. Better than most E-ranks I've seen. You interested in regular raid positions?"

"Maybe." Hayami kept their expression neutral. "Depends on the job."

"Fair enough. I'll put you on my contact list. When I need reliable combat support, I'll reach out." Sato paused. "And seriously, get a proper weapon. You've got potential, but that borrowed sword is holding you back."

Hayami looked down at the blade. The edge was chipped in three places from hitting stone armor. "Already planning on it."

Back in Tokyo, Hayami went straight to the Hunter's Market—a district near the Association headquarters where vendors sold everything from basic equipment to legendary artifacts. Most of the high-end shops were beyond their budget, but there were plenty of mid-tier options.

The first weapon shop they entered had a massive inventory: swords, spears, axes, bows, daggers, even some exotic weapons Hayami couldn't identify. A salesperson approached immediately.

"First-time buyer? What's your rank and fighting style?"

"E-rank. Lightning-based magic user with close-combat capability."

The salesperson's enthusiasm dimmed slightly at "E-rank" but remained professional. "Budget?"

"Up to ¥200,000."

That got the enthusiasm back. "Alright, let's see what we have. For a lightning user, you want something that conducts elemental energy well. Enhances your natural abilities rather than competing with them."

They were led to a section with various bladed weapons. The salesperson pulled out a short sword—maybe 60 centimeters, single-edged, with a blue-tinted blade.

"Storm Fang. D-rank weapon. Forged with conductive alloys that channel lightning-based attacks. +8 Agility, +5 Intelligence, passive ability increases lightning damage by 15%. Price is ¥180,000."

Hayami took the weapon, and the moment their hand closed around the grip, they felt the connection. Electricity flowed through the blade naturally, like it was an extension of their own body. They channeled a small amount of lightning, and the blade glowed faintly blue.

"I'll take it."

The salesperson blinked. "Don't you want to see other options?"

"This is perfect." And it was. The weapon felt right in a way the borrowed sword never had.

They also purchased: basic armor reinforcement (¥25,000), a set of throwing knives (¥15,000), and a proper combat backpack with expansion enchantment (¥30,000).

Total: ¥250,000. Leaving them with about ¥150,000 in savings. Enough for a few months of rent and food, plus emergency supplies.

Walking home with Storm Fang strapped to their hip, Hayami felt different. More prepared. More capable. Like they were finally starting to look like an actual Hunter instead of someone playing dress-up.

That night, after completing the daily quest (doubled, as always), Hayami sat on their apartment roof with the Training Manuals and their new weapon.

They'd learned something crucial today: combat experience was just as important as training. Maybe more important. The daily quests built their foundation, but fighting real monsters pushed them to adapt, to innovate, to grow in ways isolated practice couldn't replicate.

And the experience gain from higher-level monsters was significant. If they could find D-rank or even C-rank Gates with stronger enemies...

But they had to be smart about it. Today had gone well because they'd stayed in a support role, handling manageable threats while a strong team dealt with the boss. If they got overconfident and took on something beyond their capabilities, they'd end up like those three E-ranks in the Crimson Hollows.

Dead before they could realize their mistake.

Hayami channeled lightning through Storm Fang, watching the blade glow with contained energy. The weapon enhanced their power noticeably—the +5 Intelligence and 15% damage bonus made a real difference.

[STATS] (with equipment)

- Strength: 33
- Agility: 52 (+5 from boots)

- Vitality: 40 (+3 from boots)
- Intelligence: 48 (+5 from sword)
- Sense: 36

[MANA: 480/480]

Level 12. Less than a month since Awakening. Four levels gained in a single raid. At this rate, they'd hit Level 20 within two weeks if they focused on combat.

But there was something else nagging at them. The System had given them daily quests, Training Manuals, the ability to grow beyond their initial rank. It had pushed them, rewarded them, guided them toward strength.

Why?

Everyone said the System was just an interface. A display of information that already existed. But Hayami's System seemed more... intentional. Like it had a purpose beyond just showing stats.

They thought about their class designation: Mage. And their future job title from the character sheet they'd glimpsed once in a notification: Arbiter of the Primordial Cycle.

What did that mean? What was the Primordial Cycle? And why was the System training them to be its Arbiter?

Questions for another day. Right now, they had training to finish and a daily quest streak to maintain.

Hayami stood, Storm Fang crackling with lightning in their hand, and began the exercises from the Intermediate Manual.

One month ago, they were an E-rank failure with 47-watt lightning output and no combat experience.

Now they were... something else. Still weak compared to high-rankers. Still technically E-rank in the Association's eyes.

But growing. Rapidly. Exponentially.

And they were just getting started.

[END OF CHAPTER 4]